FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

It is unthinkable. But the threat of a nuclear war hangs over the subcontinent, with two nuclear-armed countries. At the heart of the simmering subcontinent lies a nuclear riddle. How and why did the sixth Indo-Pak war end so abruptly after four days of ferocious exchange of fire? The answer is still covered by a fog of half-revelations and circumstantial narratives. US president Donald Trump surprised India with his first out-of-turn 'declaration' of ceasefire on May 10, and subsequently made the claim, not once but serially, that he had saved millions of lives from a nuclear holocaust. India flatly denies any American mediation in the truce. Or of there being a nuclear dimension to the war. This does not entirely clear the mystery. Given all the unpredictable elements in play, we may never fully know whether the dramatic escalation of hostilities threatened to spiral out of control. The alarm could not be starker. You have two warlike neighbours with a combined nuclear arsenal of about 345 warheads: India 172, Pakistan 170. Enough to scorch the entire subcontinent and spread severe nuclear winter effects across the planet. Their relations frequently reach detonation point, but they yield to no formal process of dialogue to find non-military solutions to their differences. Making things even more perilous is the asymmetries in their respective political structures and nuclear doctrines, adding instability to an already combustible equation.

India maintains a No First Use (NFU) policy, committing to resort to nukes only in retaliation to a nuclear attack. Pakistan does not commit to an NFU. It has a policy of 'Full Spectrum Deterrence' that permits first use. Four conditions can trigger it: threat to its territorial integrity, military defeat, political destabilisation and economic strangulation. In short, anything perceived as a threat to its survival. Unlike India, Pakistan's arsenal also includes scores of tactical nuclear weapons. These are smaller nukes for limited battlefield use, to counter a possible land invasion by India. That makes for a decentralised command structure, dangerously leaving decision-making to the level of local commanders during a battle. A hair-trigger situation with no checks and balances.

Small or big, if Pakistan sets off even one nuke against India, Delhi promises a massive nuclear retaliation. It would mean annihilation at the city level. A Hiroshima-sized bomb dropped on a city like Karachi or Mumbai could result in over a million deaths. The fallout would spread well beyond borders. This is not speculation. It is the harsh arithmetic of deterrence theory and should serve as a chilling warning. There would be no end to this escalatory

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spiral. A horrendous scenario that should suffice to convince subcontinental leaders and their armed forces to desist from the unthinkable.

Unfortunately, conflict with India is always an existential one for Pakistan and the nuclear dimension is baked into every hostile confrontation we have had. Sadly, the two neighbours have rarely been able to sort it out without third party intervention, mainly the US. Counting over 35 years, this is the fifth time India and Pakistan have neared a flashpoint with nuclear overtones. Each time, America has stepped in to pour some coolant on the situation. It began with the Gates Mission of 1990, when the two nations weren't yet formally nuclear, and the pattern recurred during Kargil in 1999, the post-Parliament attack build-up of 2001-02 and Pulwama-Balakot in 2019. Everything about the four-day war of May 2025 evokes déjà vu. Something did indeed happen, or threaten to happen, on the intervening night of May 9-10. By most estimations, the final trigger for panic was India's strike on the Nur Khan air base in Rawalpindi. Besides its own critical operational value, it lies very near the HQ of Strategic Plans Division, which oversees Pakistan's nuclear arsenal. That proximity likely triggered concern in Washington. A regional nuclear exchange would hurt its interests and that of the world.

In Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa, who has chronicled India's nuclear weapons history in a seminal book, we have inhouse expertise on the subject. Talking to top nuclear experts across the world and officials closely involved in the recent war, he pieces together a worrying narrative. With none of the triggers of war sorted out, including terrorism, the peace remains tenuous. In New Delhi's own words, it's only a "pause".

We may have stepped away from the brink again, but the two sides cannot always rely on chance. Miscalculation is a constant threat. The two nations cannot keep playing the game of nuclear bluff. They must engage meaningfully and set up an architecture to address their respective grievances. Pakistan must realise terror is the way to end a dialogue, not start it. The US and the rest of the world must put pressure on Pakistan to stop nurturing terrorists, focus on its economy and strengthen its democracy. Its army calling the shots puts the subcontinent in a precarious state. The Modi government's all-party mission to 32 countries, to sensitise the world to Pakistan's perfidy, is a welcome step. For, there is no such thing as a limited nuclear war. There are no winners. Only regrets.

(Aroon Purie)